

MITRC

BRANDING & IDENTITY

Corey Masao Johnson
2022–2025



Founded in 1996, the MIT Rowing Club (MITRC) is the largest non-varsity rowing program affiliated with a university in the United States. Its annual roster of over 100 members range from undergraduate and graduate students to staff, postdocs, alumni, and spouses.

As the club's regatta manager from 2022–2025, I inherited the club's branding and identity package and expanded it over nine seasons.

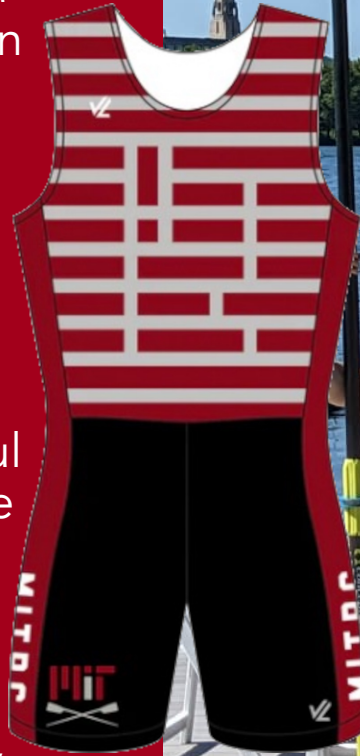


Much of the club's branding was shaped in the 2010s by MIT alum William Doss Suter, an urban planner in the Harvard Planning Office.

His uniform design hides the MIT block logo inside the striping—a quiet design hack slipped into an otherwise traditional kit.



That mix of familiarity and playful hacking (a hallmark of MIT) is the design language I've inherited: artifacts steeped in campus culture that slip easily into the rhythm of the boathouse, yet still manage to raise an eyebrow.





Hamburger Cup T-Shirts

MITRC launched the “Hamburger Cup” in 2014 as a tongue-in-cheek scrimmage with nearby schools; it’s now the country’s largest university-based club rowing invitational.

In 2022, I was asked to refresh the regatta shirt. Remastering an old design that borrowed masthead artwork from *The Tech*, MIT’s student newspaper, I used gothic type specimens to expand the letterforms and spell out MIT’s rally cry: “Go Tech!”

Traditions stay intact: MIT’s Great Dome returns as an oversized cheeseburger, and the rowers’ oars are out of sync—a reminder that the club doesn’t take itself too seriously.

Today, the redesigned print is the most ubiquitous piece of club swag on the Charles.



Travel Blazer Redesign

Blazers are central to MIT commencement—led by the 50th reunion class marshals—and to rowing culture. When Gould's of Acton, MIT's longtime blazer supplier, shuttered in 2023, we used the moment to redesign the club's travel blazer.

The new crest borrows from a longstanding Institute motif: the MIT shield, seen in Walker Memorial's floor mosaic next to a beaver. Versions with crossed oars have long marked blazers of MIT rowers at the Olympics and Henley Royal Regatta. It is also used as the logo of the MIT Crew Alumni Association (MITCAA).

Our update spells "MITRC" across both tiers of the shield, rotating the oars to better fit the pocket. Crafted by Collier & Robinson in Henley-upon-Thames, they have appeared at regattas in Europe, Asia, and North America.

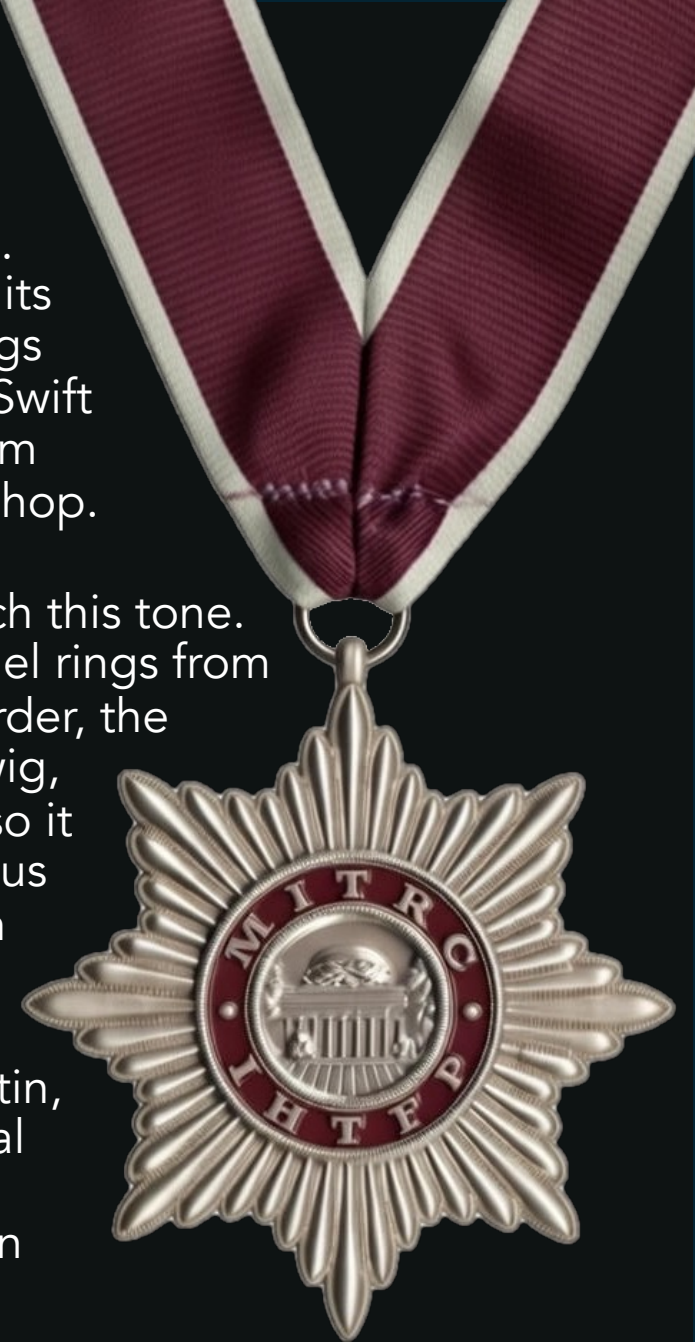


Hamburger Cup Medal Redesign

MITRC's Hamburger Cup is meant to be anything but boring. It claims a 76-year lineage despite the club being just shy of its 30-year anniversary. On race day, the dock's MIT athletics flags are swapped out for ones depicting hamburgers and Taylor Swift album art. The regatta "cup" is made of plastic, sourced from Burger King and fitted with gilt handles at a trophy shop.

In 2024, I was tasked with designing a medal to match this tone. The redesign borrows its starburst rays and enamel rings from defunct European orders—the Royal Guelphic Order, the Hungarian Order of St Stephen, the Orders of Ludwig, Leopold, Ernst, and St Alexander Nevsky—but only so it can send them up. At first glance it looks like a serious decoration; a beat later, you notice MIT's Great Dome again rendered as a cheeseburger.

The inscription cupping the dome completes the gag: no Latin, no royal cipher, just MIT's unofficial motto "IHTFP" in its usual abbreviated form. (Google at your own peril.) The design intentionally walks the line between ceremony and kitsch—an "order of merit" that embraces its own theatricality.



Coda: The Rusty Cup

Rowing culture is deep and oddly conservative, with rituals and material forms that change slowly, if at all. The goal of this work wasn't to invent a new visual grammar, but to tune into one that already exists and extend it with a wink.

Our “Rusty Cup” race with Yale Grad Crew grew from that instinct. Rhode Island’s Narragansett Boat Club proposed a spring scrimmage; we asked to invite Yale; Yale admitted they were “rusty” after the winter; the Narragansett boat captain replied that “in true collegiate fashion,” we’d just named our race.

From there, I hunted down a vintage bronze cup on eBay, had it engraved by the same shop that handles trophies for the Celtics, and fashioned a wooden base with a friend. Its surprise debut was the highlight of the regatta. The ambition throughout is to make artifacts that delight while blending in at the boathouse—steeped in tradition and built to carry the joke forward.

